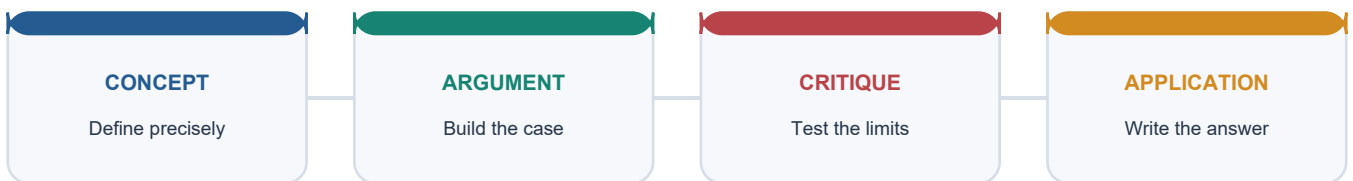


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Indian Dance - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC solved practice workbook | Full standalone render | Original MCQs, verified and withheld PYQs, solved mains and model answers

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Indian Dance - Solved Practice Workbook

This standalone workbook carries exactly 32 original MCQs with strict ABCD rotation, 6 objective/application PYQs with answer-key discipline, 8 direct solved Mains PYQs and 6 full original Mains answers.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

CORE UPSC MCQS

Q1. Which statement about Natya Shastra is safest?

A. It is safest to treat Natya Veda as a composite performance framework that combines text, enactment, music and rasa. B. It should be defined only as a manual of temple solo dancing. C. It is the same as SNA's modern eight-form list. D. Its main exam-use is proving that all classical forms remained unchanged from antiquity.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because the core source defines Natya Veda through paathya, abhinaya, geet and rasa. B is too narrow, C confuses a classical text with a modern institution, and D converts a textual framework into an unsound continuity claim.

Q2. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Nritya - dramatic enactment of a story B. Nritya - expression through gesture and emotion C. Natya - pure rhythmic movement without expression D. Lasya - exclusive legal right of women performers

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. Nritya is pure rhythmic movement, Natya is dramatic representation, and Lasya is a movement emphasis rather than an exclusive legal category.

Q3. Which statement best preserves the meaning of Lasya and Tandava?

A. Lasya belongs only to Mohiniyattam and Tandava only to Kathakali. B. Both are names for two separate UNESCO heritage lists. C. They describe contrasting movement emphases - graceful-expressive and vigorous-rhythmic - without operating as rigid gender rules. D. They are interchangeable with nritya and nritya.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because the source uses Lasya and Tandava as aspects of dance. A artificially confines them to single forms, B is unrelated, and D collapses different technical categories.

Q4. Which statement about hasta and karana is correct?

A. The number 108 refers to universal hand gestures called mudras. B. Karana is only another name for costume. C. Hasta and karana are identical terms for facial expression. D. Hasta is a codified hand gesture, whereas karana is a coordinated whole-body movement unit.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A is a common trap because 108 belongs to karanas, B misidentifies movement terminology, and C confuses body-unit vocabulary with expression.

Q5. Which statement about the classification of Indian dance forms is safest?

A. SNA's standard list has eight classical forms, and it should not be merged automatically with a Ministry list including Chhau or with UNESCO inscriptions. B. UNESCO alone decides which Indian dances are classical. C. Chhau must always be counted as one of the SNA eight. D. Any old folk dance automatically qualifies as classical.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it preserves the recognition firewall. B gives UNESCO a role it does not have, C merges separate lists, and D ignores institutional criteria.

Q6. Which Bharatanatyam recital sequence is correctly stated?

A. Tarangam -> Padhant -> Kramalaya -> Jugalbandi B. Alarippu -> Jatiswaram -> Shabdham -> Varnam -> Padam -> Jawali -> Thillana C. Mangalacharan -> Batu -> Pallavi -> Moksha D. Kelikottu -> Todayam -> Attakkatha

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because it is the Tanjore Quartet recital order. A belongs to other performance fields, C is Odissi's repertory, and D names Kathakali components rather than a Bharatanatyam recital.

Q7. Which statement best reflects the modern history of Bharatanatyam?

A. It originated as a twentieth-century academy dance with no older repertoire. B. It developed only in Mughal courts and not in the temple-performance world. C. It emerged from Sadir / Dashiattam, nearly faded with devadasi decline, and was re-presented on the modern stage through figures such as E. Krishna Iyer and Rukmini Devi Arundale. D. Its most famous signature item is Tarangam on the brass plate.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct. A and B erase the Sadir-devadasi foundation, while D transfers Kuchipudi's signature item into Bharatanatyam.

Q8. Which feature is the strongest discriminator for Kuchipudi?

A. Kasavu costume and gentle unthumped footwork B. Tribhanga with torso deflection as mobile sculpture C. Pung-led Ras Leela with veiled face D. Tarangam, in which the dancer performs on the edge of a brass plate and may balance a pot or diyas

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A points to Mohiniyattam, B to Odissi, and C to Manipuri. Tarangam is the cleanest differentiator for Kuchipudi.

Q9. Which statement about Kathakali is safest?

A. It is a Kerala dance-drama linked to Ramanattam / Krishnattam, using Attakkatha text, Manipravalam language and elaborate vesham. B. It is a solo women's form with no dramatic component. C. It is best identified by the pung drum and veiled face. D. It avoids elaborate facial make-up and prefers plain costume.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct. B describes neither Kathakali nor its troupe logic, C shifts to Manipuri, and D reverses one of Kathakali's defining markers.

Q10. Which statement about Mohiniyattam is correct?

A. It is primarily an Assamese monastic form based in sattras. B. It is a Kerala solo form marked by Kasavu costume, gentle footwork and dominant Lasya. C. It is defined by Tarangam on the brass plate. D. Its central performance language is Attakkatha.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A confuses it with Sattriya, C with Kuchipudi, and D with Kathakali.

Q11. Which statement about Kathak is safest?

A. Kathak has no pre-court history and begins only in the Mughal period. B. Kathak and Bharatanatyam are identical except for costume. C. Kathak derives from storytelling traditions, later absorbs courtly influences, and is identified by tatkar, pirouettes and gharana development. D. Kathak is the same as Chhau because both use martial movement.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it keeps temple-storytelling roots and later court history together. A erases its older base, B flattens two distinct forms, and D confuses unrelated traditions.

Q12. Which set best identifies Odissi?

A. Kelikottu, Todayam, Pacha vesham B. Kasavu, Atavus, Manipravalam narration C. Sattria, Borgeet, Mati-akhora D. Mahari-gotipua continuity, tribhanga, chowk, and a repertory such as Mangalacharan and Moksha

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A belongs to Kathakali, B to Mohiniyattam, and C to Sattriya.

Q13. Which statement about Manipuri is safest?

A. It emphasises devotion, Ras Leela and the pung drum, while keeping facial display comparatively restrained. B. It is best identified by all-male open-air troupe performance and Attakkatha text. C. It is centred on brass-plate dance and spoken dialogues. D. It belongs to the Rajasthan Kalbelia community.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct. B is Kathakali, C is Kuchipudi, and D is unrelated folk material.

Q14. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Sattriya - Tarangam B. Sattriya - sattria / Ankia Naat / Borgeet C. Sattriya - Kasavu costume and white-gold solo idiom D. Sattriya - only women performers in temple solo format

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A belongs to Kuchipudi, C to Mohiniyattam, and D invents a false performance history.

Q15. Which statement best maintains the classical-folk firewall?

A. Every folk dance becomes classical once it appears on television. B. Garba's UNESCO inscription automatically places it inside the SNA eight. C. Folk, ritual and tribal dances should be identified through community, occasion and function rather than ranked as culturally inferior to classical forms. D. Classical and folk dance never interact.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it preserves the community-function approach. A and B are institutionally false, and D denies the contact and borrowing that performance history clearly shows.

Q16. Which statement about Garba is correct?

A. It is a Sanskrit drama tradition of Kerala temples. B. It is a martial mask dance of Purulia and Saraikela. C. It is a Manipuri monastic performance with Borgeets. D. It is a Gujarati Navratri circle dance performed around a lamp-lit earthen pot and must not be confused with SNA classical status.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A points toward other Kerala traditions, B toward Chhau, and C toward Sattriya.

Q17. Which statement about Chhau is safest?

A. Chhau has three major styles - Purulia, Saraikela and Mayurbhanj - and Mayurbhanj is the style that does not use masks. B. Chhau is one of the Tanjore Quartet items in Bharatanatyam. C. All Chhau traditions are SNA-classical because UNESCO recognised them. D. Chhau is another name for Kathak's Jaipur gharana.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it preserves both style names and the mask exception. B, C and D merge unrelated categories.

Q18. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Perini - Assamese monastic dance B. Perini - warrior dance linked to Shiva and Kakatiya memory C. Perini - Bhil women's pirouetting dance D. Perini - Bodo nature-themed harvest dance

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A confuses Perini with Sattriya, C with Ghoomar, and D with Bagurumba.

Q19. Which option best identifies Bagurumba?

A. A Kerala ritual embodying local deities and spirits B. A brass-plate classical dance item in Andhra Pradesh C. A nature-themed folk dance of Assam's Bodo community D. A Manipravalam dance-drama of Kerala courts

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct. A suggests Theyyam, B Kuchipudi, and D Kathakali.

Q20. Which statement is correct about Ghoomar and Kalbelia?

A. Both are Sattriya variants performed in Assamese monasteries. B. Both are Odissi recital components. C. Both are classified as Bharatanatyam adavus. D. They are Rajasthan-based folk traditions, with Ghoomar associated with Bhil women's pirouetting movement and Kalbelia with serpent-like motion.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A, B and C relocate folk dances into wholly unrelated classical systems.

Q21. Which statement about dance and sculpture is safest?

A. Sculptural poses at Khajuraho, Konark, Ellora and Chidambaram can be read through dance vocabulary, but they do not prove unchanged modern choreography. B. Sculpture and dance must never be compared because they share no vocabulary. C. Every dancer sculpture at Khajuraho proves Bharatanatyam alone. D. The shared-vocabulary route belongs only to painting, not to dance.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it keeps the cross-topic link and its evidentiary limit together. B ignores the shared vocabulary, C overclaims, and D misstates the ownership logic.

Q22. Which statement about revival is correct?

A. Revival means elite reformers created the form from nothing. B. Revival is safest when written as preservation plus reconfiguration, because hereditary knowledge survived even while patronage and public ownership shifted. C. Revival matters only for Bharatanatyam and never for other forms. D. Revival proves that social history can be ignored.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A erases continuity, C is too narrow, and D ignores the very history that made revival necessary.

Q23. Which statement best explains guru-shishya parampara?

A. It is merely a modern bureaucratic exam system. B. It means every form has only one correct national style. C. It is the embodied transmission mechanism through which technique, correction and sampradaya survive across generations. D. It eliminates the need for rehearsal.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it captures transmission, technique and style memory together. A, B and D are distortions.

Q24. Which statement about signature postures is correct?

A. Nagabandha is the chief identifier of Mohiniyattam. B. Tribhanga belongs only to Kathak footwork. C. Chowk is a Kathakali make-up category. D. Nagabandha is associated with Manipuri, while Tribhanga and Chowk are decisive Odissi markers.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A moves a Manipuri marker into Mohiniyattam, B relocates Odissi into Kathak, and C confuses posture with vesham.

Q25. Which statement about Tandava-linked performance history is safest?

A. Perini Sivathandavam is remembered as a warrior dance in honour of Shiva and therefore helps answer old questions on Tandava's performative side. B. Tandava means only destruction and never rhythm. C. Tandava belongs only to sculpture and not to dance. D. Any fast dance anywhere can be called Tandava without source support.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it uses the source-backed Perini route. B is reductionist, C false, and D encourages unsourced inflation.

Q26. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Sattriya - pung and veiled face B. Sattriya - khol, manjira, flute and Borgeets C. Sattriya - Kasavu and white-gold saree D. Sattriya - Attakkatha in open-air lamp-lit theatre

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A belongs to Manipuri, C to Mohiniyattam, and D to Kathakali.

Q27. Which statement about Kathakali vesham is safest?

A. Green signifies wickedness and black signifies sainthood. B. Mohiniyattam uses vesham categories such as Pacha and Kathi. C. Kathakali uses distinct make-up types such as Pacha, Kathi, Thadi, Kari and Minukku, with colour-significance built into character presentation. D. Vesham is simply another word for Tarangam.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct. A reverses colour logic, B misplaces Kathakali's grammar, and D confuses make-up coding with a Kuchipudi item.

Q28. Which set correctly reflects the Odissi repertory rail?

A. Alarippu -> Jatiswaram -> Shabdham -> Varnam B. Kelikottu -> Todayam -> Attakkatha C. Padhant -> Jugalbandi -> Tarana -> Kramalaya D. Mangalacharan -> Batu nritya -> Pallavi -> Tharijham -> Moksha / Trikhanda Majura

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A is Bharatanatyam, B Kathakali, and C Kathak recital vocabulary.

Q29. Which comparison between Bharatanatyam and Mohiniyattam is safest?

A. Bharatanatyam is marked by a stronger rhythmic architecture and Tanjore-recital order, whereas Mohiniyattam is lasya-dominant with gentle footwork and Kasavu costume. B. Mohiniyattam is famous mainly for Tarangam on the brass plate. C. Bharatanatyam is defined by sattr and Borgeet. D. Both forms are best distinguished only by language, not movement.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it uses discriminating features. B moves in a Kuchipudi signature, C in a Sattriya context, and D ignores technique.

Q30. Which conclusion about Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi is correct?

A. Both forms are historically identical and differ only in dress colour. B. Bharatanatyam grows from Sadir-devadasi recital culture, whereas Kuchipudi retains a stronger travelling dance-drama and dialogue-linked profile. C. Kuchipudi is the form of veiled devotional restraint based on pung. D. Bharatanatyam alone uses mudras, while Kuchipudi does not.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A erases distinct performance histories, C describes Manipuri, and D ignores shared classical grammar.

Q31. Which statement best preserves the SNA-UNESCO distinction?

A. UNESCO inscription is the same as recognition as one of the classical forms. B. Once a form enters UNESCO's list, it should replace all older regional labels. C. SNA classical status and UNESCO inscription measure different things - canon formation on one side, safeguarding of living heritage on the other. D. Therefore Garba should always be counted in the SNA eight.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it states the institutional distinction exactly. A and B collapse two different regimes, while D misapplies UNESCO recognition to classical-list counting.

Q32. Which statement should be avoided in a UPSC answer?

A. Hallisalasaya may illuminate the dance-painting boundary, but its secure ownership remains with Painting Topic 07. B. When a form shares posture vocabulary with sculpture, that does not automatically prove unchanged choreography. C. If a question asks about a form's recognition, the answer should separate SNA, Ministry and UNESCO tracks. D. Because Hallisalasaya concerns dance, it is safe to shift its direct factual ownership from Painting Topic 07 into Topic 09 and treat it as a core dance route.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is selected because it is the unsafe statement. The knowledge system keeps Hallisalasaya routed to Painting Topic 07; it can be used only as a boundary link here. A, B and C are the safe controls because they preserve ownership discipline and evidence limits.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED OBJECTIVE / APPLICATION PYQS

PYQ 1. Which one of the following was the latest inclusion in the Intangible Cultural Heritage List of UNESCO? (a) Chhau dance (b) Durga puja (c) Garba dance (d) Kumbh mela (CSE 2024)

Answer: C.

Why C is correct: The locally held official Set-A paper gives this exact wording, and the locally held official Set-A answer key records Q60 = C. Garba of Gujarat was inscribed on UNESCO's Representative List in 2023, later than Chhau (2010), Kumbh Mela (2017) and Durga Puja (2021).

Why the others are wrong: Chhau, Kumbh Mela and Durga Puja are all real Indian intangible-heritage entries, which is why the options are close. The question tests chronology within UNESCO's ICH route; it does not test SNA classical status.

PYQ 2. Consider the following pairs: (i) Garba : Gujarat (ii) Mohiniyattam : Odisha (iii) Yakshagana : Karnataka Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched? (a) (i) only (b) (ii) and (iii) only (c) (i) and (iii) only (d) (i), (ii) and (iii) (CSE 2014)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: This question tests exact region-form matching. Garba belongs to Gujarat and Yakshagana to Karnataka, while Mohiniyattam belongs to Kerala rather than Odisha. The elimination logic is strong, but the final official objective key is not locally verified in the official key bank used for this repair, so the letter is withheld.

PYQ 3. With reference to the famous Sattriya dance, consider the following statements: (i) Sattriya is a combination of music, dance and drama. (ii) It is a centuries-old living tradition of the Vaishnavites of Assam. (iii) It is based on classical Ragas and Talas of devotional songs composed by Tulsidas, Kabir and Mirabai. Which of the statements given above is/are correct? (a) (i) only (b) (i) and (ii) only (c) (ii) and (iii) only (d) (i), (ii) and (iii) (CSE 2014)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: Statements (i) and (ii) are source-owned because Sattriya combines dance, music and drama and remains a Vaishnava living tradition of Assam. The third statement is unsafe because the Assamese devotional music field is tied to Sankaradeva's Borgeets, not to a Tulsidas-Kabir-Mirabai attribution. The official answer letter remains withheld pending verified official key support.

PYQ 4. In the context of cultural history of India, a pose in dance and dramatics called 'Tribhanga' has been a favourite of Indian artists from ancient times till today. Which one of the following statements best describes this pose? (a) One leg is bent and the body is slightly but oppositely curved at the waist and neck. (b) Facial expressions, hand gestures and make-up are combined to symbolise certain epic or historic characters. (c) Movements of body, face and hands are used to express oneself or to tell a story. (d) A little smile, slightly curved waist and certain hand gestures are emphasised to express the feelings of love or eroticism. (CSE 2013)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The repair package defines tribhanga as the three-bend posture central to Odissi and also legible in sculpture. Therefore the best answer must describe the body's three-part bend rather than a general theory of expression or make-up. Since the final official key is not locally verified, the option letter is withheld.

PYQ 5. How do you distinguish between Kuchipudi and Bharatanatyam dances? (i) Dancers occasionally speaking dialogues are found in Kuchipudi dance but not in Bharatanatyam. (ii) Dancing on the brass plate by keeping the feet on its edges is a feature of Bharatanatyam but Kuchipudi dance does not have such a form of movements. Which of the statements given above is/are correct? (a) (i) only (b) (ii) only (c) Both (i) and (ii) (d) Neither (i) nor (ii) (CSE 2012)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: Statement (i) fits the dance-drama ecology of Kuchipudi, while statement (ii) is false because brass-plate Tarangam belongs to Kuchipudi rather than Bharatanatyam. This is a classic comparison question on discriminating features. The answer letter remains withheld because no locally verified official key was used for this older paper.

PYQ 6. Match List I with List II and select the correct codes: List-I (Dancer) A. Kalamandalam Kshemavathy B. Kottakkal Sivaraman C. Lakshmi Viswanathan D. N Madhabi Devi List-II (Dance) (i) Kathakali (ii) Manipuri (iii) Mohiniyattam (iv) Bharatanatyam A B C D (a) (i) (iii) (ii) (iv) (b) (iii) (i) (iv) (ii) (c) (i) (iii) (iv) (ii) (d) (iii) (i) (ii) (iv) (CSE 2011)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The source itself supplies the crucial associations: Kalamandalam Kshemavathy with Mohiniyattam, Kottakkal Sivaraman with Kathakali, Lakshmi Viswanathan with Bharatanatyam and N. Madhabi Devi with Manipuri. Therefore the solving logic is stable even though the final official UPSC objective key is not locally verified in the repository's official bank.

DIRECT MAINS PYQS WITH MODEL ANSWERS

PYQ-M1. Discuss the 'Tandava' dance as recorded in early Indian inscriptions. (CSE 2013)

Model solution

Tandava should not be reduced to a crude image of violence. In the Indian dance tradition, Tandava denotes the vigorous and rhythmic aspect of dance, contrasted with the graceful-emotive field of Lasya. Early inscriptional and temple traditions connect this vigorous mode especially with Shiva, whose Nataraja image later becomes the most recognisable civilisational emblem of cosmic rhythm.

In answer-writing, the safer route is not to hunt unsourced inscription names but to explain what the tradition records. Tandava stands for energy, dynamic body movement, rhythmic emphasis and performative force. That is why later forms such as Perini Sivathandavam, the warrior dance associated with Kakatiya memory and Shiva worship, are useful explanatory bridges: they show how the vigorous side of dance became ritualised and historically embodied.

The best conclusion is that Tandava is an interpretive category of movement in Indian dance history. It belongs to the Natya Shastra performance vocabulary and later sculpture-dance iconography, and it should be explained through energy, rhythm and Shiva-linked performative symbolism rather than through sensationalism.

PYQ-M2. Describe the Bagurumba folk dance. (CSE 2012)

Model solution

Bagurumba is a well-known folk dance of Assam's Bodo community. It is nature-themed and is performed with music using instruments such as the sifung, kham and serja. Unlike a classical form identified through fixed textual grammar, Bagurumba is rooted in community performance and regional ecology.

Its importance lies in what it preserves. The dance translates landscape, rhythm and local social memory into movement. That is why the safest way to describe it is through community and theme rather than by forcing it into the framework of a classical dance form. In a GS-I answer, Bagurumba can be used to show that Indian dance history is not exhausted by elite classical canons.

Thus Bagurumba is best described as a Bodo folk dance of Assam in which nature, community and music together shape performance.

PYQ-M3. List the classical dance forms of India as per Sangeet Natak Akademi? (CSE 2011)

Model solution

As per the standard Sangeet Natak Akademi list used in this topic, the eight classical dance forms are:

1. Bharatanatyam
2. Kuchipudi
3. Kathakali
4. Mohiniyattam
5. Kathak
6. Odissi
7. Manipuri
8. Sattriya

The stronger answer does not stop at listing. It should immediately add the classification caution that this SNA eight-form list must not be carelessly merged with a separate Ministry list including Chhau or with UNESCO intangible-heritage inscriptions such as Garba.

PYQ-M4. List the salient features of the important folk dances of central India or North Eastern India. (CSE 2009)

Model solution

The salient features of folk dances of central and North-Eastern India are best organised through region, community and occasion.

Central India

- **Gaur Muria (Chhattisgarh):** ritual dance of the Muria tribes of Bastar; imitates the bison; group performance by men and women.
- **Raut Nacha (Chhattisgarh):** associated with the Yadav community and especially visible around Diwali.
- **Rai Nritya (Madhya Pradesh):** Bundelkhand dance associated with the Bedia tribe, often described as peacock-like.
- **Jawara / Matki (Madhya Pradesh):** harvest, festival and balancing-performance settings.

North-East

- **Bihu (Assam):** lively group dance with brisk steps and colourful dress.
- **Bagurumba (Assam):** Bodo nature-themed dance.
- **Hojagiri (Tripura):** lower-body movement with balancing skill during Lakshmi Puja.
- **Garia / Lebang Boomani (Tripura):** sowing and harvest-cycle associations.
- **Cheraw (Mizoram):** bamboo-stick dance.
- **Thang-Ta (Manipur):** martial performance based on sword and spear.

The comparative conclusion is that these forms preserve labour, harvest, ritual and martial memory rather than imitating classical dance.

PYQ-M5. Write about Perini Sivathandavam. (CSE 2008)

Model solution

Perini Sivathandavam is a martial dance tradition associated with Telangana and Kakatiya memory. It is performed in honour of Lord Shiva and is often described as a warrior's dance. Nitin also links it to sculptural depiction near the garbha gudi of the Ramappa Temple at Warangal, which gives the form a useful architecture-dance bridge.

Historically, its importance lies in the performative use of vigour. Perini carries the Tandava side of dance in a distinctly martial direction: the body becomes a medium of mobilisation, devotion and heroic energy. This separates it from lyrical lasya-oriented forms.

Therefore, Perini Sivathandavam is best understood as a Shiva-linked, warrior-oriented performative memory of the Deccan, not merely as an energetic folk routine.

PYQ-M6. Write a short note on Kathakali. (CSE 1992)

Model solution

Kathakali is Kerala's celebrated dance-drama tradition. It grew out of the performance world of Ramanattam and Krishnattam and retains close links with Koodiyattam and martial performance. The very name joins *ka* (story) and *thali* (play or performance).

Its chief features are elaborate character-specific make-up and headgear, generally all-male troupe performance, Attakkatha text, Manipravalam language, minimal props, and powerful use of eyes, eyebrows and hand gestures for representing the *rasas*. Chenda and maddala drums create the dramatic frame. It is often staged in open-air or temple-premises settings with a brass lamp.

Kathakali thus represents the fullest dance-drama integration within the Indian classical spectrum.

PYQ-M7. Write a short note on the Manipuri dance. (CSE 1991)

Model solution

Manipuri is the major classical dance tradition of Manipur and is deeply tied to Vaishnava devotional performance. Krishna and Ras Leela form its recurring thematic centre, while the pung drum and the restrained emotional field of performance sharply identify the form.

The dance is known for devotional emphasis rather than overt sensuality. Facial display is comparatively restrained, the face may be veiled, *lasya* is prominent, and graceful hand-knee movement is central. Nagabandha is one of its important posture-markers. Historically, Raja Bhag Chandra's revival and Tagore's later introduction of the form at Santiniketan are major milestones.

Manipuri is therefore best described as a devotional classical form where rhythm, grace and Krishna-centred enactment are fused within a distinct regional idiom.

PYQ-M8. What are the main forms of classical dance in India? Indicate two features of each. (CSE 1988)

Model solution

The main classical dance forms in the standard Sangeet Natak Akademi list are Bharatanatyam, Kuchipudi, Kathakali, Mohiniyattam, Kathak, Odissi, Manipuri and Sattriya.

- **Bharatanatyam:** Sadir-devadasi origin; Tanjore Quartet recital order and *adavu*-based grammar.
- **Kuchipudi:** Kuchelapuram village association; Tarangam and dance-drama line.
- **Kathakali:** Attakkatha and elaborate *vesham*; eye-brow-led dance-drama.
- **Mohiniyattam:** Kasavu costume; gentle *lasya*-oriented footwork.
- **Kathak:** *tatkar* and *pirouettes*; storytelling and *gharana* history.
- **Odissi:** *tribhanga* and *chowk*; *mahari-gotipua* continuity and sculptural quality.
- **Manipuri:** Ras Leela and *pung*; devotional restraint.
- **Sattriya:** *sattri*-monastic setting; Borgeet and Ankia Naat connection.

A high-scoring answer closes by warning that SNA classical status is distinct from UNESCO inscription or from a Ministry list including Chhau.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Q1. Explain the contribution of Natya Shastra to Indian dance. Why is terminological precision central to scoring in this topic? (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Natya Shastra gives Indian dance its foundational grammar by treating performance as a composite of text, enactment, music and *rasa*. That is why dance is analysed through categories rather than through vague appreciation. It provides the conceptual frame within which later traditions work.

Terminological precision is central because UPSC repeatedly tests close distinctions. **Nritta** is pure rhythmic movement, **Nritya** is expressive dance, and **Natya** is dramatic enactment. **Lasya** and **Tandava** are contrasting movement emphases, not rigid gender categories. **Hasta** differs from **karana**, and the famous number **108** belongs to the latter.

Without this precision, a candidate cannot distinguish Bharatanatyam from Kuchipudi, Odissi from Manipuri, or SNA status from UNESCO safeguarding. Therefore Natya Shastra contributes not only an ancient text but also the vocabulary that makes answer-writing accurate.

Original Q2. Bharatanatyam should be written as continuity plus reconstruction rather than as either timeless survival or modern invention. Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Bharatanatyam is best understood as a reconfigured continuity. Its repertoire grows out of **Sadir / Dashiattam**, the performance of temple dancers or devadasis in Tamil Nadu. This gives the form a deep pre-modern base.

Yet its modern public life emerged only after disruption. The decline of the devadasi system weakened the hereditary performance world, after which figures such as **E. Krishna Iyer** and **Rukmini Devi Arundale** worked to revive and restage the form. Meanwhile the **Tanjore Quartet** had already codified the recital order, giving the repertoire a structured performance spine.

Thus Bharatanatyam is neither a pure museum-survival nor a twentieth-century invention. Continuity lies in repertoire, movement grammar and transmission; reconstruction lies in patronage, public stage, institutional prestige and social ownership.

Original Q3. Compare Kathak and Kuchipudi through origin, technique and performance ecology. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Kathak and Kuchipudi are both classical forms, but their performance ecologies are markedly different.

Origin: Kathak derives from the storytelling line of **Kathikas** and from the Raslila world of North India. Later, Mughal courts reshaped its presentation and helped generate distinct gharanas. Kuchipudi, by contrast, is tied to **Kuchelapuram** village in Andhra Pradesh and to travelling actors or **Kusselavas**, later shaped through Siddhendra Yogi and Bhagavata-centred dance-drama.

Technique: Kathak is identified by **tatkar**, pirouettes, padhant and rhythmic interplay such as **jugalbandi**. Kuchipudi shares classical grammar but foregrounds dance-drama, occasional dialogue and signature virtuosity through **Tarangam** on the brass plate.

Performance ecology: Kathak moves through temple-storytelling, court patronage and gharana transmission within the Hindustani performance world. Kuchipudi remains more clearly linked to Telugu narrative enactment, Vaishnava themes and Carnatic accompaniment.

Conclusion: Therefore, the safest comparison is not North versus South, but storytelling-court-lineage on one side and village-dance-drama on the other.

Original Q4. Discuss Odissi as a meeting point of dance, sculpture and revival history. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Odissi is one of the strongest examples of how Indian dance connects bodily grammar with sculptural imagination and historical reconstruction.

First, dance grammar. The form is defined by **Tribhanga** and **Chowk**, torso-led movement, expressive hand gestures and a repertory sequence moving from **Mangalacharan** to **Moksha**.

Second, sculptural link. Odissi is often described as **mobile sculpture** because the dancer's body creates curves, geometry and rhythmic stillness-in-motion comparable to sculptural postures. This is why the form becomes valuable in answers linking dance with Khajuraho, Konark or other temple figures.

Third, historical continuity. The tradition remembers **Mahari** practice, later **Gotipua** continuity and the court variant called **Nartala**. In the mid-twentieth century, figures such as **Charles Fabri** and **Indrani Rahman** contributed to wider public visibility.

Qualification: Sculpture proves a valued movement idiom; it does not prove unchanged named choreography.

Conclusion: Odissi thus stands at the junction of ritual memory, sculptural vocabulary and modern revival.

Original Q5. Examine the difference between institutional recognition and living practice in the history of Indian dance. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

The history of Indian dance becomes distorted when institutional recognition is confused with living practice.

Institutional recognition is modern and classificatory. The standard **Sangeet Natak Akademi** list identifies eight classical forms, while a separate Ministry list includes **Chhau**. UNESCO inscription, as in the case of **Garba of Gujarat** in 2023, belongs to safeguarding of living heritage, not to classical canon formation.

Living practice, however, is older and socially layered. Bharatanatyam's modern status emerged out of Sadir and the devadasi performance world; Odissi drew upon Mahari and Gotipua memory; Sattriya remained tied to Assamese satras; Kathakali changed after feudal decline. A form's regional and community life therefore often long predates its institutional recognition.

This distinction matters analytically. It prevents three mistakes: treating classical status as timeless essence, turning UNESCO recognition into proof of classicality, and erasing the hereditary communities whose labour sustained the repertoire.

Conclusion: Recognition tells us how the state or international bodies classify and safeguard a form; living practice tells us where, by whom and through what historical changes the form actually survived.

Original Q6. Discuss the significance of folk, ritual and martial dances in understanding Indian culture. Why should they not be treated as leftovers beside classical dance? (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Folk, ritual and martial dances are indispensable for understanding Indian culture because they preserve local memory in embodied form.

Folk dances such as **Garba**, **Bihu**, **Bagurumba**, **Ghoomar** and **Kalbelia** encode festival, harvest, gendered community participation, serpent symbolism or regional social rhythm. **Ritual dances** such as **Theyyam** and **Padayani** embody deity, myth and temple-community relations. **Martial dances** such as **Chhau**, **Perini** and **Thang-Ta** preserve combat memory, discipline and heroic performance.

They should not be treated as leftovers because their grammar is structured by occasion and function. They are not "failed classical forms"; they are different performance systems. In fact, they often tell us more directly about labour, devotion, seasonal cycles and local belief than elite courtly performance does.

A mature answer also keeps modern recognition in perspective. UNESCO inscription or public festivals can widen visibility, but they do not dissolve the community base from which these forms emerged.

Conclusion: Indian cultural history is incomplete if classical dance alone is studied. Folk, ritual and martial forms preserve the social body of culture.